

PRELUDE TO A POLICE STATE

In a thoughtful book, Thant Myint-U traces the roots of Burma's modern predicament through history

THE RIVER OF LOST FOOTSTEPS: HISTORIES OF BURMA

by THANT MYINT-U

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■ By Sam Miller

Most modern-day writing about Burma tends to be steeped in indignation. Much of this indignation—at the continued incarceration of pro-democracy leader Aung San Suu Kyi, at the country's human rights record, the treatment of minorities, and the widespread use of forced labour—is justified, but it does not always help explain how Burma has become the world's most enduring military dictatorship. Thant Myint-U takes a more thoughtful approach. In this intelligent and accessible book, he traces the roots of Burma's modern predicament through history. He starts with a detailed depiction of two of Burma's defining moments: the overthrow of King Thibaw by the British in 1885, and the emergence, a century later, of Burma's pro-democracy movement. He uses these dramatic events as a way of drawing his readers into the chronological narrative that follows.

Thant is both an insider and outsider. He is the grandson of U Thant, who was secretary-general of the United Nations for most of the 1960s. The author was also for many years a UN official, and although he has lived most of his life outside Burma, he was briefly involved in the democracy movement in the late 1980s. He skillfully incorporates his own family story into his narrative, giving a more human dimension to Burma's modern political history. He is almost uniquely placed to explain Burma to the world, and to place Burmese history in a global context. And, fortunately, he is very keen not to bore his readers, and tells many entertaining tales.

Although *The River of Lost Footsteps* is a serious book, it is not intended as an academic one. This seems to be the only possible reason

why his publishers have not included an index. There are a few other minor problems. Thant uses some strange archaisms—Colas instead of Cholas, Chettyars rather than Chettiers. He talks about Malwaris when he means, presumably, Marwaris, and thinks Ratnagiri is south of Goa. In a memorable history-compressing passage, he points out that the British could have replaced Thibaw with his half-brother, the Prince of Pyinmana, who died, Thant informs us, in the same week in the summer of 1963 when the Beatles went on their first tour. Unfortunately, he spoils his story by telling us later in the book that the Prince died in 1956.

who wrote in Sanskrit and Pali; and the Burmese language eventually came to be written in a modified Dravidian script. Thant, in one of his most powerful pieces of historical writing, describes the rise of the Arakanese kingdom on India's border, and the exile and execution there of Shah Jehan's son Shah Shuja. Indian migrants briefly became the majority community in many Burmese cities during British rule, only to leave in huge numbers on Independence and during the 1960s, as Burma began to close itself off to the rest of the world.

Thant, in his conclusion, agonises over the current situation in Burma (he



There is much in this book that will be of specific interest to an Indian reader. According to the foundation myth of the Burma monarchy, the country's first king was an Indian, Abhiraja, from the royal family of Kosala. Buddhism came to the country through two Burmese merchants who encountered the Buddha during their travels in India. They offered him rice cakes and honey, and in return he gave them eight strands of hair from his head. These were enshrined in the great Shwedagon pagoda that dominates the skyline of modern Rangoon. There were medieval Burmese kings

never uses Myanmar, the name used by the military government) and argues that sanctions and isolation are the wrong policies to use against the regime. "If Burma," he points out "were a country where those in charge wanted to engage with the outside world, then a policy of sanctions might make sense." But they don't, he says. Rather, they thrive on isolation, and therefore Thant calls for more trade, more tourism, more engagement. He is pessimistic about the prospects of short-term change, and believes that the conditions for progress to democracy could take a decade or two to emerge. ■